

Climate Civic Festival

A post-hackathon independent policy proposal on climate education, civic trust and green backlash

Independent public policy project | Version 1.0 | July 2026

Project note: An exploratory undergraduate policy project developed after a collaborative policy hackathon. The proposal is intended for public discussion and may be revised as evidence and feedback develop.

Abstract

An annual Climate Civic Festival would give students in England's secondary, further education and inclusion settings a structured opportunity to develop climate projects and present them at a public school or college event. The proposal treats green backlash as a problem of civic trust and agency: support for climate ambition becomes politically fragile when policy feels costly, remote or unfairly imposed. Existing education policy offers a delivery route through climate action plans and the national enrichment framework. The festival would add a climate-specific civic purpose centred on evidence use, local fairness and democratic participation. Meta-analyses find positive average effects from climate and environmental education, with the strongest gains in knowledge and smaller gains in attitudes and behaviour. Intergenerational research supports parent-facing delivery, while motive-alignment studies favour student agency. Japan's Tokkatsu and school-festival tradition supplies an institutional precedent for recurring student-led public events. A national programme would cost about £65 million a year under the central planning estimate. The preferred funding model is a proposed Treasury allocation equal to 2.5% of forecast UK Emissions Trading Scheme receipts, supported by a capped Electricity Generator Levy equity fund. A preregistered cluster-randomised pilot should test the complete model before national expansion.

Keywords: climate education; green backlash; civic trust; school enrichment; UK ETS; Tokkatsu; public policy; climate misinformation

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1. Executive summary

An independent post-hackathon project provides the basis for this proposal. The project takes green backlash as a live public-policy problem and develops an education response designed for realistic funding, delivery and evaluation. The Climate Civic Festival would operate annually across secondary schools, FE colleges and inclusion settings in England. Students from Year 7 upward would form groups, choose a climate-related project and prepare it over several weeks. Each cycle would culminate in a public festival involving the school community and invited local partners. Project routes would accommodate different forms of achievement. A group might investigate local flood risk and present practical recommendations.

Green backlash presents a civic trust and agency challenge. Public concern about climate change remains broad, while urgency and policy confidence weaken under cost pressure and cultural polarisation. Recent DESNZ data show high concern; King's College London, Ipsos and CAST record a marked fall between 2021 and 2025 in the share wanting net zero before 2050 (DESNZ, 2026a; King's College London, Ipsos and CAST, 2026). The festival would build long-run civic capacity by teaching students how to use evidence, assess fairness and discuss local policy in public.

Existing policy provides a plausible delivery architecture. DfE guidance asks settings to appoint sustainability leadership and develop climate action plans, including a pillar on climate education and green skills (Department for Education, 2025a). England's national enrichment framework also recognises civic participation and external partnership (Department for Education, 2026c). The festival would combine these structures into a focused climate-civic entitlement.

Evidence supports a cautious trial of the component mechanisms. Formal climate education improves knowledge and produces smaller average gains in attitudes and behaviour (Aeschbach et al., 2025). Broader environmental education research reports positive effects across cognitive and behavioural outcomes (van de Wetering et al., 2022). Structured child-to-parent education can increase parental climate concern, including among initially less-concerned groups (Lawson et al., 2019). Adolescent studies also indicate that agency-sensitive framing can improve selected forms of engagement (van de Wetering et al., 2025; Spitzer et al., 2026). Japan's Tokkatsu tradition provides a delivery precedent for recurring student-led public events (MEXT / EDU-Port Japan, 2022; Tsuneyoshi, 2012). The pilot would test whether this form produces climate-specific effects in England.

National rollout is estimated at about £65 million a year. The estimate covers institutional grants, inclusion support and the central capacity needed for resources and evaluation. A proposed Carbon Market Civic Dividend would allocate Treasury funding equal to 2.5% of the OBR's 2025-26 forecast for UK ETS receipts. Current rules direct those receipts to the Consolidated Fund, so implementation requires an explicit spending decision. A capped Electricity Generator Levy allocation would finance equity support and protect the scheme during lower-receipt years (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2026a; HM Treasury, 2026; HMRC, 2026a).

Table 1. Policy design summary

Design element	Policy position
Policy mechanism	Annual student-led Climate Civic Festival in secondary, FE, special and alternative provision settings, with local adaptation.
Scale	Pilot first, followed by national entitlement once unit costs, workload and outcome estimates are established.
Cost	About £65m per year after rollout; pilot evidence will validate the grant formula.
Funding	Treasury allocation equal to 2.5% of forecast UK ETS receipts, supported by a capped EGL equity fund.
Evidence claim	Research supports the component mechanisms; the pilot tests the combined effect on green backlash.
Evaluation	Preregistered cluster-randomised pilot, using stepped-wedge rollout when operationally necessary.

2. Reflective rationale and project method

The project began with a collaborative policy-design exercise on climate backlash. Time limits and panel scrutiny forced the group to prioritise clarity, political legibility and economic feasibility. The independent project develops an education-policy route in greater depth and retains those practical constraints.

Group discussion produced a redistributive principle: climate-related market receipts should finance part of the social capacity needed for transition. The independent proposal formalises the principle through two revenue routes. The primary route allocates a share of UK ETS allowance-auction receipts. Allocating auction receipts avoids a new levy on secondary-market trading and its potential liquidity effects. A capped allocation from the scheduled Electricity Generator Levy increase would support high-need communities. Together, the routes link climate-related fiscal receipts to civic climate capacity.

The project uses a four-stage policy method. The first stage diagnoses backlash as a civic trust problem. The second identifies a delivery route in current education policy. The third combines climate-education evidence with a festival model. The final stage develops a costed funding and evaluation plan. The resulting document is a policy design and evidence synthesis. Its claims concern a proposed intervention whose effects require empirical testing.

Evidence status: Existing research supports the proposed mechanisms. The pilot would test the combined festival's effect on climate knowledge, civic trust and green backlash.

3. The policy problem: green backlash as a trust and agency challenge

Green backlash is resistance to climate policy driven by perceived cost, unfairness or institutional distance. The concept gathers related mechanisms under one analytic frame. Economic insecurity covers household burden and regional job anxiety. Political interpretation covers mistrust, misinformation and perceived status threat. The festival primarily targets the civic pathway while allowing projects to examine material distribution.

UK public attitudes combine widespread concern with declining urgency. DESNZ's Winter 2025 tracker found 90% awareness of the 2050 net zero target, 77% concern about climate change, 68% support for government action and 12% opposition (DESNZ, 2026a). The Spring 2026 tracker recorded concern at 78% and found uneven knowledge by education level (DESNZ, 2026b). ONS data placed climate change and the environment among the important issues named by 57% of adults in October 2024, down from 69% in July to August 2023 (ONS, 2024). King's College London, Ipsos and CAST report that support for reaching net zero before 2050 fell from 54% in 2021 to 29% in 2025, while 64% still supported the 2050 target or an earlier date (King's College London, Ipsos and CAST, 2026).

The pattern raises a problem of political durability. Climate concern remains widespread, yet support for specific measures can weaken. Citizens interpret policy through beliefs about fairness, expertise and place. Civic climate education can strengthen their capacity to scrutinise claims, recognise uncertainty and build locally credible proposals.

Youth politics adds a design constraint. Young people are politically heterogeneous. NatCen's British Social Attitudes analysis reports lower Reform UK support among younger adults than older adults in its party-supporter sample, alongside a large education divide between adults below A-level and graduates (NatCen, 2026a). A separate NatCen report identifies educational experience as a major predictor of divides over immigration and right-wing politics (NatCen, 2026b). The findings function as proxy evidence and leave the causal relationship between school disaffection and green backlash unresolved. The policy implication is narrower: climate education should provide credible routes for students whose identities and aspirations are practical or vocational.

European research also records meaningful far-right support among young adults and a gender gap in this support (Milosav et al., 2025; Off, 2025). UK evidence requires separate interpretation because young men remain more progressive than older male cohorts on several measures (IPPR, 2026). One implication is that climate education should assume political heterogeneity and give students visible agency through a high-status public format.

Table 2. Backlash mechanisms and design responses

Backlash mechanism	Policy response
Perceived cost and unfairness	Projects examine who pays, who benefits and how local livelihoods are affected.
Low institutional trust	Students test claims, use local evidence and meet local actors through structured public engagement.
Educational disaffection	Project routes give equal status to academic, practical and community-based achievement.
Misinformation and polarisation	Projects compare sources, test claims and explain uncertainty in plain language.
Negative association with disruptive tactics	Use evidence-based deliberation and community design as the civic method.

4. Current education-policy baseline and the civic implementation opportunity

Existing policy provides the foundation for delivery. DfE strategy and guidance already place climate action within education settings. Climate action plans should address four pillars: adaptation and resilience; biodiversity and nature; climate education and green skills; and decarbonisation and net zero. DfE also links visible plans with parent and community engagement, which can support trust and accountability (Department for Education, 2025a).

National climate initiatives also demonstrate delivery capacity. After its first year, the National Education Nature Park involved more than 4,000 settings, and students had mapped about two million square metres of habitat (Department for Education, 2025b). A common national framework can therefore reach schools when it supplies practical activities and usable resources.

Enrichment policy created a second delivery route in June 2026. The national framework sets eight benchmarks and places civic engagement alongside broad participation and external partnership. The Every Child Can programme commits £132.5 million to enrichment (Department for Education, 2026c; Department for Education, 2026d). Existing infrastructure therefore makes an annual festival administratively plausible.

The remaining policy opportunity is a climate-specific civic entitlement. Current arrangements support sustainability leadership and enrichment; the festival would use them to organise evidence-based discussion of local climate choices. Students would examine fairness, involve families and present practical outputs. Delivery through enrichment preserves curriculum space and leaves examination structures unchanged.

Student voice evidence supports this approach. In a British Science Association survey, 72% of UK respondents aged 14 to 18 wanted more climate education and 68% wanted climate change included across subjects. Respondents encountered the issue mainly through science and geography and wanted stronger links to local solutions (British Science Association, 2023). Cross-curricular research reaches a similar conclusion: climate education should integrate critical thinking and media literacy with practical local inquiry (Anderson, 2024).

5. Policy proposal: the Climate Civic Festival

An annual national entitlement would be delivered through schools and colleges with local flexibility. Central government would set minimum standards, fund teacher time and supply the common evidence and evaluation infrastructure. Education settings would adapt projects to local circumstances with support from local authorities, academy trusts and partner organisations.

5.1 Core design

Each setting would run six short preparation sessions across about six weeks and one public festival day. Student teams would choose a climate-related project. Every project would use evidence, produce a public output and explain its approach to fairness or community benefit. These minimum standards preserve the civic purpose and leave substantial room for student ownership.

Table 3. Project routes

Project route	Illustrative output
Academic research	A local survey on one contested issue, followed by a short evidence report.
Sport and fundraising	A football tournament supporting a local green-space or home-energy charity.
Practical design	An audit of one school resource, followed by practical recommendations.
Media and communication	A short video or podcast comparing claims about one contested issue.
Vocational and careers	A project with a local employer on one green-skills pathway.
Community deliberation	A student-led panel where local stakeholders discuss a real climate policy trade-off.

5.2 Entitlement and adaptation

Every student from Year 7 upward would receive an annual opportunity to join a climate civic project. Key Stage 3 participation would emphasise discovery and creativity. During exam years, Key Stage 4 students could contribute through mentoring, evidence summaries or festival-day presentation. Sixth-form and FE students could lead advanced projects connected to research methods or vocational pathways.

Coverage would extend to mainstream secondary schools, FE colleges and secondary-age inclusion settings. Special schools and alternative provision require adapted resources, flexible event formats and staff support. A differentiated model makes the entitlement meaningful across varied forms of provision.

5.3 Civic method

The festival would culminate in a public event. Schools could combine exhibitions with one additional format suited to local interest, such as a student-led debate. Parents and community partners would encounter climate questions through students' work. Public presentation gives students a civic role and creates a route for intergenerational discussion.

Disruptive protest provides a useful boundary case for the civic method. A 2023 Bristol survey found strong public disapproval of Just Stop Oil (University of Bristol, 2023). Experimental research suggests that disruption can increase issue salience and generate backlash against particular demands or groups (Vandeweerd, 2025). Media analysis also finds substantial variation in portrayals across outlets and tactics (Scheuch et al., 2024). The festival uses a different method: evidence-based deliberation and practical community design.

6. Japan case study: school festivals as civic education infrastructure

Japan supplies an institutional precedent for the festival form. Its school-festival tradition shows how annual student-led public events can become part of educational culture when schools protect time, distribute responsibility and connect the event to civic aims. The Japanese evidence concerns educational form. Climate-specific effects remain a question for the English pilot.

Tokkatsu, or special activities, provides the institutional framework. MEXT-linked guidance presents it as a setting in which children participate in group life, solve shared problems and build consensus under teacher guidance (MEXT / EDU-Port

Japan, 2022). Whole-child education research places Tokkatsu within the curriculum and links it to cooperative school culture (Tsuneyoshi, 2012).

Culture festivals, or bunkasai, show the framework in practice. Government-linked descriptions report widespread student participation and extended preparation through executive committees. Some schools give students responsibility from planning through operation (Japan National Tourism Organization, 2022). Web Japan also describes cross-class collaboration and shared responsibility (Web Japan, 2024).

Empirical research offers modest support for these design principles. In one junior-high study, stronger perceived group development during festival plays was associated with autonomy, cooperation and mutual understanding; teacher support for conflict resolution was also associated with better group development (Taruki and Ishikuma, 2006). A retrospective survey of 645 university students linked strong school-event involvement with later organisational citizenship in extracurricular groups, with some effects shaped by self-determination (Kubota-Kawamoto, 2021). Their main value lies in implementation guidance, while causal impact remains unresolved.

Transfer to England requires institutional adaptation. Tokkatsu is embedded in Japanese curriculum culture and daily school routines. The English model should borrow its core principles of student ownership and guided cooperation. Table 4 translates these principles into the proposed design. Climate content and impact evaluation would remain specific to the English context.

Table 4. Japan case study and design translation

Japanese precedent	Design lesson for the Climate Civic Festival
Tokkatsu as curriculum-anchored special activities	Link the festival to climate action plans, enrichment and subject learning.
Whole-school participation in culture festivals	Provide universal participation through varied project roles.
Student-led planning and operation	Give students real project choice and visible responsibility.
Teacher-guided cooperation and reflection	Fund teacher scaffolding, conflict resolution and post-festival review.
Public-facing school culture	Invite families and local institutions.

7. Evidence base and theory of change

Evidence supports several components of the proposal, while the complete intervention remains untested. Climate education can plausibly improve knowledge and selected attitudes. Parent-facing delivery may create intergenerational discussion, and agency-sensitive design may improve engagement. The pilot must establish whether the combined festival model strengthens civic trust and resilience to green backlash.

7.1 Climate and environmental education

Formal climate education produces positive average effects, with the largest gains in knowledge. A 2025 meta-analysis reported Hedges' g values of 0.77 for knowledge, 0.39 for attitudes and 0.36 for behaviour (Aeschbach et al., 2025). Hedges' g expresses change in standard-deviation units across different measures. The review also found substantial heterogeneity and possible publication bias, especially for knowledge, and many included studies used pre-post or quasi-experimental designs. One implication is that the festival requires contextual evaluation.

Broader environmental education research reaches a similar conclusion. A meta-analysis covering 169 studies, 512 effect sizes, 176,007 participants and 43 countries found the largest effect for knowledge, at $g = 0.953$. Smaller positive effects appeared for attitudes, at $g = 0.384$; intentions, at $g = 0.256$; and mostly self-reported behaviour, at $g = 0.410$ (van de Wetering et al., 2022). Substantial heterogeneity supports subgroup analysis in the pilot.

7.2 Intergenerational spillover

School-based climate education can influence family attitudes. In an experimental study in North Carolina, parents whose children received a structured climate curriculum expressed greater concern than control-group parents. Effects were particularly strong among male and conservative parents and through daughters (Lawson et al., 2019). The US curriculum and English festival differ in format, so the pilot should test transfer directly. The finding justifies a parent-facing event.

7.3 Adolescent agency and motive alignment

Adolescent engagement is sensitive to how action is framed. A preregistered Dutch experiment found that rebellion-aligned framing increased pro-environmental intentions and petition signing, whereas mandatory framing reduced donation behaviour (van de Wetering et al., 2025). Field evidence from the Netherlands and China found positive immediate effects from motive alignment, with mixed persistence across outcomes (Spitzer et al., 2026). The combined evidence supports student choice and public responsibility as design principles. It also motivates follow-up measurement.

7.4 Misinformation and media literacy

Climate backlash develops partly through contested information environments. A systematic review identifies media literacy, corrective information and trustworthy information settings as recurring responses to manipulation around climate change

(Herasimenka, Wang and Schroeder, 2025). Experimental testing remains limited. Festival projects can translate these approaches into source comparison and public explanation of uncertainty.

7.5 Socio-economic disadvantage and educational disaffection

Socio-economic context shapes climate learning. The OECD reports lower sustainability outcomes among students with weaker science performance, fewer socio-economic resources and less environmentally aware parents (OECD, 2024). The policy response is targeted capacity: additional funding should support practical projects, vocational links and local employer involvement. NatCen's evidence on educational divides in right-wing support adds a political reason for the same approach (NatCen, 2026a; NatCen, 2026b).

7.6 Theory of change

Table 5. Theory of change

Stage	Mechanism	Measured outcome
Inputs	Ring-fenced grants, funded teacher time and shared resources.	Settings deliver the festival with funded support.
Activities	A student-led project cycle followed by one public festival day.	Participation and project completion; attendance by families and partners.
Learning	Students compare evidence, discuss trade-offs and produce public work.	Climate knowledge, media literacy and understanding of fairness.
Agency	Students choose roles suited to their strengths and interests.	Perceived agency, self-efficacy and willingness to discuss climate policy.
Spillover	Families and local actors encounter climate work through students.	Parent concern, trust and willingness to discuss local climate policy.
Longer-run effect	Future citizens evaluate ambitious climate policy with greater civic competence.	Resilience to misinformation and backlash, measured over time.

8. Costing, revenue and fiscal feasibility

Funding determines whether the proposal becomes a genuine entitlement or an unfunded expectation. Delivery therefore requires a ring-fenced grant, published unit costs and a workload model validated through the pilot. A transparent revenue rule should protect the programme from annual administrative discretion.

8.1 Costing assumptions

National rollout is provisionally estimated at about £65 million a year. The figure is a planning estimate because institutional grants and central costs require pilot validation. The calculation uses the DfE's 2025-26 schools release and includes a separate allocation for special and alternative provision settings (Department for Education, 2026a). A universal secondary-age entitlement requires dedicated support for learners outside mainstream schools.

Table 6. Central annual cost estimate after rollout

Cost item	Assumption	Estimated annual cost
Mainstream secondary school grants	3,458 state-funded secondary schools at £10,000 each, using the DfE 2025-26 release.	£34.58m
FE college grants	210 English colleges at £15,000 each, focused on eligible 16-to-19 provision.	£3.15m
Inclusion allocation	Indicative support for special schools and state-funded AP settings; the pilot will refine the formula.	£4.21m
Deprivation, rural and post-industrial top-up	Additional capacity funding for communities facing structural delivery constraints.	£10.00m
National resources and digital project bank	Shared evidence packs, project templates and evaluation tools.	£5.00m
Regional coordination and independent evaluation	Regional support, qualitative fieldwork, data analysis and annual reporting.	£6.00m
Administration and contingency	Procurement, data protection, quality assurance and price variation.	£2.10m
Total	Rounded annual national programme estimate.	about £65.0m

Core schools funding provides a scale comparison. DfE statistics place it at £65.3 billion in 2025-26 and £67 billion in 2026-27 (Department for Education, 2026b). A £65 million programme equals roughly 0.10% and 0.097% of those totals respectively. The comparison includes different institutional scopes because the festival also covers FE and inclusion settings; its role is to indicate fiscal scale.

The project's costing developed through successive source checks. Earlier drafts used BESA counts and the November 2025 OBR profile; the present estimate uses the June 2026 DfE schools release and March 2026 OBR outlook (BESA, 2026; Office for Budget Responsibility, 2025).

8.2 Carbon Market Civic Dividend

The preferred revenue source is a Carbon Market Civic Dividend, defined as an explicit Treasury allocation equal to 2.5% of forecast UK ETS receipts. Businesses in the UK ETS acquire emissions allowances through auction, secondary trading or free allocation. The four UK administrations jointly constitute the UK ETS Authority (UK ETS Authority, 2026). Allocating auction receipts translates the original group idea of taxing carbon trading into an administratively simpler mechanism and leaves secondary-market liquidity unchanged.

Current fiscal rules require an explicit spending decision. DESNZ's audited Trust Statement records £2.52191 billion in UK ETS auction income for 2024-25, paid into the Consolidated Fund (DESNZ, 2025). The OBR's March 2026 outlook forecasts £2.6 billion in receipts for 2025-26 and a slight rise by 2030-31; sustained carbon-price weakness would reduce later receipts (Office for Budget Responsibility, 2026a). HM Treasury confirms that ETS revenue accrues to the Exchequer under current arrangements (HM Treasury, 2026). The proposed dividend is a budgetary allocation created through Treasury and parliamentary approval.

Table 7. Carbon Market Civic Dividend scenarios

Revenue base	2.5% equivalent	Policy implication
OBR 2025-26 forecast: £2.6bn	£65.0m	Funds the central programme estimate.
DESNZ audited 2024-25 UK ETS auction income: £2.52191bn	£63.05m	Requires a small reserve, a 2.58% allocation or EGL equity top-up to reach £65m.
Illustrative £3.0bn receipt year	£75.0m	Creates a reserve for high-need settings, evaluation and cost inflation.

The UK-wide ETS creates a territorial funding question because the initial education proposal applies to England. A UK-wide festival co-designed with devolved administrations offers the most coherent settlement. An England-only programme would require equivalent devolved allocations through the normal spending framework. Either route needs Treasury approval and intergovernmental agreement.

8.3 Electricity Generator Levy equity top-up

Incremental Electricity Generator Levy receipts provide a supplementary equity source. The rate rises from 45% to 55% on 1 July 2026 for qualifying electricity-generation receipts. The levy applies to exceptional returns earned by certain generators during periods of high wholesale prices and is legally separate from the Energy Profits Levy on oil and gas production (HMRC, 2026a; Office for Budget Responsibility, 2026b).

EGL receipts fell to £0.7 billion in 2024-25, a 49% annual decline associated with lower wholesale prices (HMRC, 2025). Energy Profits Levy receipts reached £2.9 billion in the same year. A static calculation applies the ten-point rate increase to the earlier taxable base: $£700 \text{ million} \times 10/45 = £155.6 \text{ million}$ on an annualised basis. A nine-month first-year equivalent is about £116.7 million. These scenarios assume an unchanged taxable base. Actual receipts will respond to prices, contracts for difference, company behaviour and qualifying-period timing.

A capped Climate Civic Equity Fund of £10 million to £15 million a year would use part of any incremental EGL revenue. Funding would target settings facing structural capacity constraints, with eligibility defined through deprivation and accessibility measures. The fund could also cover temporary UK ETS shortfalls. Capping the allocation preserves the redistributive principle and recognises the volatility of EGL receipts and their existing fiscal uses.

Table 8. Funding appraisal

Funding route	Strength	Risk	Design response
UK ETS allocation	Direct link between carbon pricing and climate civic capacity; current forecast scale can fund the programme.	Receipts vary and current rules send revenue to the Consolidated Fund.	Create an explicit Treasury allocation with a reserve and published annual calculation.
Secondary-market transaction levy	Closest to a literal tax on trading activity.	May affect liquidity and requires separate market-design work.	Reserve for consultation after a separate market-design assessment.
EGL equity top-up	Links windfall-style energy receipts to high-need communities.	Receipts are volatile and already linked to wider fiscal objectives.	Cap at £10m-£15m and dedicate the allocation to equity support.
Education budget fallback	Protects continuity in low-receipt years.	Competes with existing school pressures.	Use as a reserve guarantee for pilot years or exceptional shortfalls.

9. Educational time, staffing and workload feasibility

The scheme requires a small annual time entitlement. The central model allocates three hours of preparation across six weeks and one festival day. Optional clubs and independent group work can extend preparation according to local capacity.

Table 9. Time allocation

Time element	Illustrative allocation
Preparation	Six 30-minute sessions drawn from existing form, curriculum or enrichment time.
Festival day	One annual enrichment day of about 6.5 hours.
Total protected time	About 9.5 hours per year.
Share of annual mainstream school time	About 0.77% of a 32.5-hour, 190-day school year.

The time estimate is illustrative. DfE guidance sets a 32.5-hour week expectation for state-funded mainstream schools, and maintained schools usually open for 380 sessions or 190 days (Department for Education, 2023; House of Commons Library, 2023). Across 38 weeks, this equals about 1,235 hours. A 9.5-hour festival programme represents roughly 0.77% of annual on-site time. FE, sixth-form and inclusion settings operate different timetables, so the pilot must test separate delivery models.

Teacher workload is the principal implementation risk. The National Audit Office reports that more than one-third of secondary teachers leave the state-funded sector within five years of qualification. Among recent leavers surveyed by DfE, 84% cited high workload and 75% cited stress or wellbeing (National Audit Office, 2025). Ring-fenced funding should support a named Festival Lead, ready-made resources and short evaluation tools. Teachers would facilitate projects through funded preparation time.

National support should provide a complete delivery kit. Core materials would include project menus, local-data templates and safeguarding guidance. Schools could then adapt the kit to their timetable and community. FE colleges would connect projects to vocational departments and employer partnerships; special and alternative provision settings would use adapted formats and smaller-group outputs.

10. Evaluation design and safeguards

Evaluation should begin at pilot stage through a preregistered cluster-randomised design. Random allocation would occur at school or college level. Operationally phased delivery could use randomly assigned rollout waves in a stepped-wedge structure. The analysis plan should address clustering, baseline differences, calendar effects, attrition and multiple outcomes.

The evaluation should distinguish outcomes by distance from the intervention. Proximal measures would cover climate knowledge, evidence use and perceived agency. Intermediate measures would examine parent engagement, misinformation resilience and trust in local decision-making. Longer-run follow-up would assess sustained civic participation and resilience to backlash. A post-festival survey captures early effects; follow-up at six and twelve months would test persistence.

Parent evaluation requires a representative sampling strategy. Recruiting only festival attendees would select families who are already more engaged. The evaluation should establish a parent panel before invitations and follow the same respondents after the event. Qualitative interviews with disengaged students and local partners would test whether the scheme reaches its intended audiences.

Table 10. Risks and safeguards

Risk	Safeguard
Perceived politicisation	Teach evidence evaluation and civic argument through a clear impartiality framework.
Teacher workload	Fund lead time and provide common resources and short evaluation tools.
Superficial projects	Require evidence, local relevance, a public output and a short fairness reflection.
Unequal capacity	Use inclusion and rural top-ups, regional support and a shared project bank.
Low engagement from disaffected students	Give equal status to academic, practical and community-based routes.
Weak direct emissions effect	Define the programme as civic-capacity infrastructure and report environmental co-benefits separately.

11. Policy appraisal

11.1 Ambition and effectiveness

The policy's ambition is political and generational. Formal climate targets depend on civic conditions that sustain support through contested implementation. The festival would strengthen those conditions through climate literacy, media literacy and public participation across the student population. Parent-facing delivery extends the intervention into local communities.

One reason in favour of the policy is that four evidence streams converge on its component mechanisms. Climate education improves knowledge and selected attitudes. Child-to-parent interventions can influence adult concern. Motive-alignment research supports agency-based delivery. UK attitude data identify a gap between broad concern and declining urgency. The effect on green backlash remains a testable hypothesis, so the proposal couples ambition with a rigorous pilot.

11.2 Practicability

Practicability comes from using existing institutions. Climate action plans and the national enrichment framework provide the delivery route, while existing partnerships can supply local expertise. Examination and qualification structures would remain unchanged. Mainstream schools would allocate about 9.5 protected hours each year, and central grants would fund staff time and materials.

Fiscal design also supports delivery. At the current forecast level, a Treasury allocation equal to 2.5% of UK ETS receipts would meet the central cost estimate. A capped EGL fund would support high-need settings. Both mechanisms require explicit spending decisions under current rules.

11.3 Rigour

Rigour comes from a specified theory of change, cautious claims and built-in evaluation. The pilot would measure knowledge, agency and misinformation resilience before testing broader outcomes such as trust and parent engagement. Subgroup analysis would identify which project routes work across different settings. The design therefore treats awareness as one intermediate mechanism within a wider civic intervention.

One difficulty is that the available evidence is uneven. Knowledge effects are stronger than behavioural effects, and many behaviour measures are self-reported. Japanese evidence supports the festival form, whereas climate-specific attitude change requires English evaluation. The £65 million estimate also remains a planning case until the pilot validates unit costs.

11.4 Creativity

Creativity lies in turning climate education into a public civic festival. Curriculum-based programmes typically focus on content. The proposed model adds whole-school participation and student ownership through varied project routes. Public presentation connects learning to families and local institutions.

The festival also creates a recognisable annual ritual. Its public and participatory form gives students space to argue from evidence, demonstrate practical work and receive community recognition. Climate citizenship becomes an activity students can shape and present.

12. Implementation roadmap

Table 11. Implementation roadmap

Phase	Action	Output
Year 1 pilot	Run a stratified pilot across about 200 mainstream secondaries, 20 FE colleges and selected inclusion settings. Use cluster randomisation where feasible.	Test resources, outcome measures, inclusion adaptations, unit costs and workload.
Year 2 expansion	Expand to one-third of eligible settings through local and regional delivery partnerships.	Publish the first evidence report and refine the funding formula.
Year 3 national entitlement	Offer grants to all eligible settings, subject to Treasury and territorial funding decisions.	Establish the festival as a recognised route for climate action plans and enrichment.
Year 4 refinement	Adjust project routes, parent engagement and equity support using evaluation findings.	Identify the most effective routes for agency, parent engagement and misinformation resilience.

Central government would hold responsibility for standards, funding and evaluation. Local authorities, academy trusts and FE partnerships would coordinate local organisations. Education settings would deliver student projects, and external partners would contribute expertise and public audiences. The resulting model combines national entitlement with local relevance and student ownership.

13. Limitations and ethics

Five limitations define the pilot agenda. First, the complete model remains unevaluated, while existing research supports individual mechanisms. The pilot must therefore estimate effects on trust, parent engagement and green backlash. Second, project quality will vary with institutional capacity, which makes funding and resource support part of the intervention. Third, political impartiality requires clear guidance on evidence, contested policy and classroom discussion. Fourth, student and parent data require privacy safeguards, transparent consent and limited retention. Fifth, the funding model requires Treasury approval and a territorial settlement because UK ETS receipts enter the Consolidated Fund through a four-nation scheme.

The limitations define the value of a pilot. Credibility depends on making uncertainty explicit, pricing delivery conditions and treating evaluation as part of implementation.

14. References

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Appendix A. Calculation notes

1. UK ETS dividend: $2.5\% \times £2.6\text{bn} = £65.0\text{m}$. Using audited DESNZ auction income for 2024-25, $2.5\% \times £2.52191\text{bn} = £63.05\text{m}$. Full funding from the audited figure would require an allocation of about 2.58%.
2. EGL static uplift: $£700\text{m} \times (55 - 45) / 45 = £155.6\text{m}$ on an annualised unchanged-base scenario. A nine-month first-year equivalent is about £116.7m. The figures are illustrative scenarios and carry no official forecast status.
3. School time: $32.5 \text{ hours} \times 38 \text{ weeks} = 1,235 \text{ hours}$. Dividing 9.5 hours by 1,235 gives 0.769%, rounded to 0.77%. The percentage applies to mainstream school-time assumptions; FE, special and AP settings require separate testing.
4. Programme cost: £65m is the central planning scenario. The pilot should test whether the grant formula needs a stronger per-pupil component or additional inclusion weighting.